

BUILD vs. BUY: The decision framework for AI in accounting firms

In collaboration with **RADICAL+**

A litmus test for firm leaders navigating the vibe coding era

A few years ago, “build vs. buy” was a clean binary. Fast forward to 2026 and the decision isn’t so simple anymore. Vibe coding — using AI to generate working software from natural-language prompts — has dramatically lowered the cost of prototyping, and AI-native products are emerging faster than any firm’s procurement cycle can absorb. At the same time, the hidden costs associated with maintenance, governance, security and productionization have increased. The useful question is no longer “should we build or buy?” Instead firms should consider, “What should we own, what should we buy, and what should we build around?” For many firms, this isn’t just a technology decision, it’s a capex vs opex decision, with all of the accounting consequences that come with it.

Before you apply this framework, do the product-level thinking first. See the companion video at CPA.com/AI on how to build a holistic technology strategy so that AI decisions always fit within the firm’s business model.



The framework: Three conditions

1 Build if it's a one-off

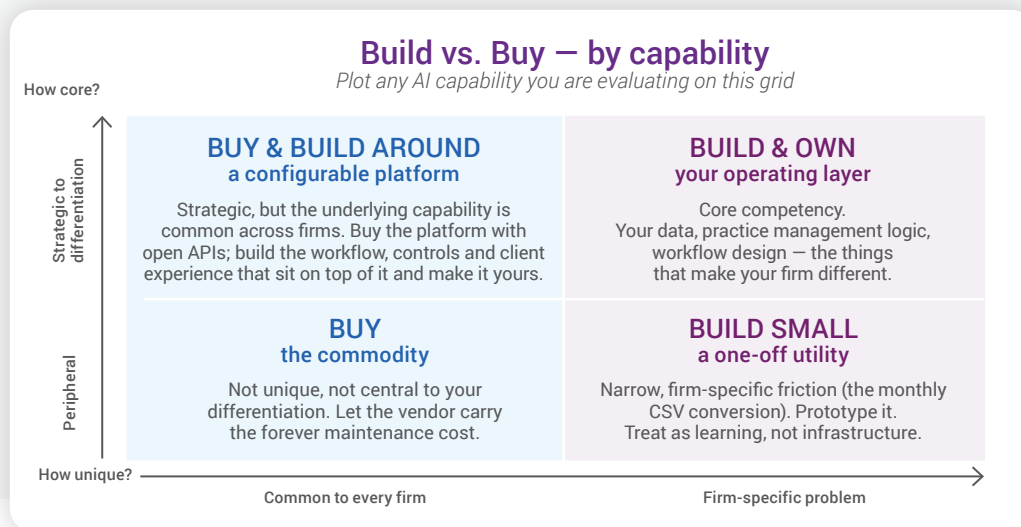
Narrow, local, firm-specific or time-boxed – a one-time migration, a hyper-specific client need, or work you don't expect to be doing long term and not worth a full procurement process. This is where rapid AI-assisted building shines. Classic example: One client uses a unique tool, and every month your team manually reformats a CSV to fit your tax/audit system. Perfect candidate for a small, purpose-built utility.

2 Build if it's a core competency

Central to how your firm differentiates, operates or delivers value. For most firms, this is the operating layer: how work is orchestrated, how data flows, how your people and clients move through your systems. When that layer is a real source of differentiation, it belongs to the firm.

3 Buy if it's neither

The real cost of software is not creating it, it's maintaining it forever. Choose consolidated platforms with open APIs, and avoid stitching a dozen narrow vendors into a fragile tower where one broken integration cascades through the stack. The foundational systems that run your business, but are not specific to your firm alone, are clear *Buy* decisions. Examples: General ledgers, practice management and tax prep.



Common failure patterns

- **Shadow IT:** Teams independently build or adopt AI tools with no oversight, turning undocumented custom tools into mission-critical risks.
- **Cross-client data leakage:** In multi-client environments, the model retrieving or referencing the wrong client's data is the failure mode most firms underestimate.
- **Pricing-model whiplash:** Vendors are shifting from per-user to consumption-based (token) pricing. The cost you signed up for at procurement may not be the cost in 18 months.
- **Key-person risk:** If the person who built the internal tool leaves, the tool often leaves with them. Custom builds need owners, documentation, and IP agreements.
- **Maintenance blind spot:** The cost to build is visible; the cost to maintain is consistently underestimated and ignored.

The litmus test

For any capability or tool your firm is evaluating, walk through these six questions. If most answers point in the same direction, then you have arrived at the strategic direction to pursue:

1 Is this problem unique to our firm, or do many firms experience similar problems?

Unique > lean build. Common > someone is (most likely) already building a product for it.

2 Would owning this differentiate us or just replicate what vendors offer?

Differentiating > build. Parity > buy.

3 Could we prototype this (in reasonable time) to test the idea?

4 If we build it, who owns it in three years?

Who maintains it, supports users, patches security, handles model changes? If “we haven’t thought about that” is the answer, then you need to define these parameters or elect to buy.

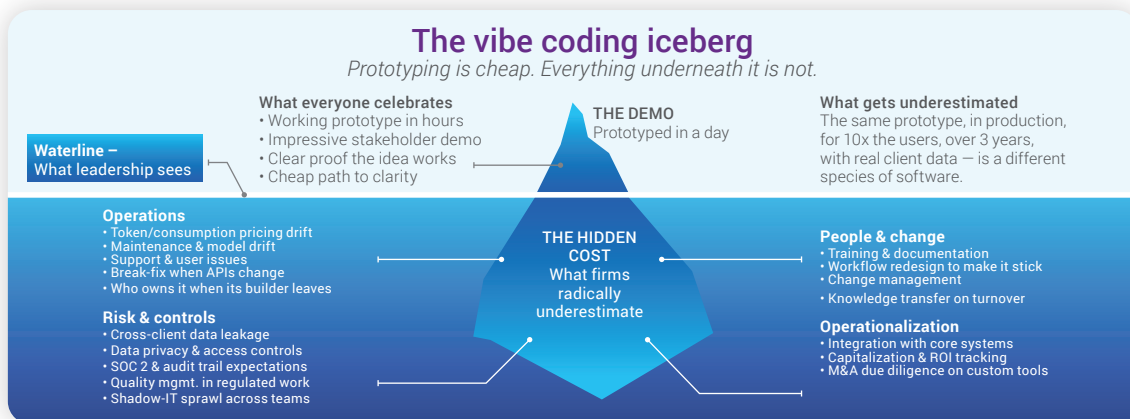
5 If we buy it, what happens if the vendor is acquired, pivots or raises prices?

6 Is this a regulated, high-risk or sensitive-data workflow like audit, attest, tax filing and accesses sensitive client PII?

Custom tools here need governance and security maturity that most firms haven’t yet built. How confident are you that your ‘builders’ can secure it? When in doubt, buy from a vendor who already has.

What vibe coding changes, and what it doesn't

AI-assisted building has changed the economics of experimentation, not the economics of operational durability. The demo is visible but the real costs are hidden beneath the surface.



Bottom line

- Buy the core systems that every firm needs. Build the one-offs that only your firm has.
- Own the firm-specific operating layer where your differentiation lives.
- Understand all of the security risks.
- Avoid fragile towers of disconnected tools.
- In every case, respect the hidden cost of maintenance as well as token pricing.

Before you decide on which approach to take, also ask yourself if you are solving the right problem. Firms forcing AI into old workflows will increase complexity, not solve for it. The firms that will win with AI will not be the firms that build the most software, they will be the firms that make the right decisions on what to build, why and how while still purchasing software that supports their business model.



Developed by the CPA.com AI Working Group in collaboration with radical+. For deeper guidance on evaluating AI solution partners, see the companion resource: [*AI Solution Due Diligence Guide for Accounting Firms*](#) at [CPA.com/AI](https://cpa.com/AI).

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